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COMMITTEES:
EDUCATION AND LABOR
DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA

Congress of the United States
House of Representatives
Washington, D. C.

SECRETARIES:
WASHINGTON
T. J. REARDON, JR.

BOSTON
FRANCIS X. MORRISSEY

May 22, 1951

Dear ------:

I want to thank you very much for your communication in regard to President Truman relieving General MacArthur of his responsibilities in the Far East.

While no one can question the right of the President to relieve the General of his command, I regret that the President felt it necessary to relieve him in such an abrupt and summary manner.

But the basic issue now, however, is whether we should follow the recommendations of General MacArthur as to our policy in the Far East, or whether we should maintain our present policy of attempting to limit the struggle in Korea.

General MacArthur made four basic recommendations in his speech to the Congress, and he developed them in some detail in his testimony before the Senate Committees on Foreign Relations and Armed Services:

1) He recommended that the island of Formosa be held, and not turned over to the Chinese Communists. With that recommendation I am in complete agreement, and have been since 1949.

2) He recommended that an economic and naval blockade be instituted to stop the flow of vital strategic materials to the Chinese Communists. I believe that an economic blockade should be instituted as quickly as possible, and that a naval blockade should be carried out if it is felt to be feasible by the Chiefs of Staff. On May 9th, in the House of Representatives I introduced a resolution which would deny economic assistance, except under the Mutual Aid Program, to any nation that continues to ship material useful in war to Communist China.

3) He recommended that the Nationalist troops on Formosa be put to use. Before the Chinese Communists intervened last December in Korea, the decision had been made not to use Nationalist troops for two reasons: (1) it might encourage the Chinese Communists to enter the struggle, and (2) it might weaken the defense of Formosa. As reason number one is no longer germane, I would use Nationalist troops in South Korea, provided it does not weaken the defense of Formosa. I would not at this time use Chiang Kai-shek's troops against the mainland, as it would require increasing many-fold the American commitment in that area, with only a limited chance of success.

4) I would not at this time bomb Manchuria or China as the General recommended.

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General MacArthuur believes that if his recommendations were accepted it would result in pressure being put on the Chinese to force them to pull out of Korea.

My only objection to following completely the recommendations of General MacArthur is that it will spread the war beyond the borders of Korea, and might result in the intervention of Soviet Russia and the commencement of World War III.

While it is extremely difficult for me to support the present method of fighting a war of attrition in Korea, which takes a heavy toll of American lives, I do believe that as long as we can hold in South Korea, we should not take the risk of enlarging the war at a time when we are relatively weak in relation to the power of the Soviets.

I regret that I must disagree in this way with General Douglas MacArthur, for whom I have the greatest personal respect, and whose ability, courage and forthrightness cannot be questioned.

It is my hope that out of the current investigation into our Asian policy by the Senate Committees on Foreign Relations and Armed Services, a program can be evolved that will receive the support of all Americans.

Sincerely yours,



John F. Kennedy, M. C.